Every day, as more of his mansabdars and their troops joined him, the camp expanded, until ‘it soon seemed to hide the earth’, writes Monserrate, sprawling out over more than two kilometres, ‘covering the fields and filling the woods’. Should a wild animal find itself embroiled in the mass of marching feet, it could not break through. ‘Even the birds,’ the Jesuit continues, ‘wearied by trying to fly out of danger, and terrified by the shouts of the soldiers, fall down exhausted to the earth.’

By the end of it, according to the Father, there were 500 elephants, 50,000 horsemen and an ‘almost countless’ infantry: Mongols and Persians, Turks and Uzbeks, Baluchis and Pathans; Hindus and Muslims, each with their own fighting styles.

Rajputs would ride into battle ‘on little ponies hardly as big as donkeys’, writes Monserrate, dismount on the battlefield ‘and await the attack of the enemy armed with short spears . . . and light shields’. Baluchis rode camels[26] and used bows and arrows; while Hindustanis had turned elephants into terrifying war machines. They might dash a soldier to the ground and trample him: ‘They do not cease from crushing their wretched victims till they are ground and smashed to pieces,’ the Father explains. They might toss others ‘into mid-air, so that they are killed by the fall’, or they might ‘split [a man] in twain by placing a foot on one of their victim’s legs, seizing the other leg with their trunk and tearing it forcibly upwards’. (‘They can even be taught to dance,’ concludes Monserrate blithely.[27])

The Persians and Central Asians were no less deadly. They were ‘most dangerous’, writes the priest, when ‘flying in headlong riot’. It might seem as if the soldiers were caught in a frenzy of speed, but as they galloped past, they could turn around ‘on their horses . . . [and] fling their javelins with such deadly aim that they can transfix the eye of an enemy’.

Father Monserrate does not mention them, but the infantry would also have included an elite corps of *bandukchi*s, matchlock-men, Akbar foremost among them. Guns were not only increasingly important to any serious arsenal, they were also one of Akbar’s passions. Abul Fazl reports in the *Ain-i-Akbari* that the emperor even invented new kinds of guns: one that could fire seventeen barrels with a single shot, another that could be taken apart and reassembled. Hindustan, writes Abul Fazl, had more guns for ‘securing the government’ than any empire except Turkey, the